

Pornography

prc-pornography

Marriage & Sexuality · Sexual Ethics · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

Pornography use is sin: adultery of the heart, exploitation of those in the industry, and corrosive of the marriage bed.

In plain language

The question asks whether using pornography is sin. The word pornography is modern and does not appear in the canon, so the lexical work first identifies the constituent acts of the practice (the desiring look at a person depicted for sexual interest, the engagement of sexual immorality, the use of the body apart from honor) and then asks what the original languages say about each. The clearest text is Matthew 5 verses 27 and 28. Jesus repeats the old command, you shall not commit adultery, and then says that everyone who looks at a woman in order to lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart. The grammar is decisive. The present participle for looking is governed by a purpose construction meaning in order to desire, so the verse does not address an accidental glance but a look whose aim is lust. The verb for committed adultery stands in the aorist with the adverb already, marking the guilt as complete, and the locative phrase fixes the act in the heart. The text places the moral violation precisely at the deliberate desiring look, which is the defining act of viewing sexual images. Paul ties the same vocabulary together in 1 Thessalonians 4 verses 3 to 5, where the will of God is sanctification, defined as continuing to abstain from porneia and refusing to live in the passion of lust like the nations that do not know God. Porneia is a broad word covering the whole field of illicit sexual activity, and 1 Corinthians 6 verse 18 commands flight from it as the sin against one's own body. Two wisdom texts discipline the eye directly. Job 31 verse 1 uses the strongest Hebrew oath idiom, to cut a covenant, applied to the eyes, so as not to gaze on a young woman. Psalm 101 verse 3 refuses to set anything worthless before the eyes. Proverbs 6 verse 25 forbids desiring beauty in the heart and being captured by the eyelids, joining heart and eye exactly as Jesus does. The convergence is what makes this verdict decisive rather than disputed. Three independent strands of the canon, the Decalogue extended by Jesus, the wisdom guarding of the eye, and the Pauline sanctification ethic, all locate the sin at the same juncture, the intentional look that engages sexual desire and the indulgence of porneia. Readers who hesitate to call viewing such images sin usually argue that the depicted person is not the looker's own neighbor, or that an image is not a person. The lexical objection is answered inside the text. Matthew 5 verse 28 fixes guilt at the look aimed at lust, not at any subsequent action toward the woman, and Paul forbids the passion itself, regardless of how it is provoked. On these grounds the lexical evidence affirms that the practice is sin.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0995	בין	bin	to understand	160
H1100	בליעל	beliyaal	Belial	27
H1285	ברית	berith	covenant	266
H1330	בתולה	bethulah	virgin	47
H1697	דבר	dabar	word	1,454

H2530	חָמַד	hamad	to desire	21
H3772	כָּרַת	karath	to cut	289
H5003	הָאֵף	naaph	to commit adultery	31
H5048	נֶגֶד	neged	before	
H5869	עַיִן	ayin	eye	887
H6079	הַפָּפַיִם	afappayim	eyelid	10
H7896	שִׁית	shith	to set	86
G0038	ἁγιασμός	hagiasmos	holiness	10
G0568	ἀπέχω	apecho	to have in full	19
G0991	βλέπω	blepo	to see	136
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	167
G1538	ἐκαστος	hekastos	each	91
G1937	ἐπιθυμέω	epithymeo	to long for	16
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithymia	desire	38
G2235	ἤδη	ede	already	65
G2307	θέλημα	thelema	will/desire	63
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2509	καθάπερ	kathaper	just as	15
G2588	καρδία	kardia	heart	161
G2932	κτάομαι	ктаομαι	to posses	8
G3361	μή	mē	not	
G3431	μοιχεύω	moicheuo	to commit adultery	14
G3806	πάθος	pathos	passion	3
G4202	πορνεία	porneia	sexual sin	26
G4314	πρός	pros	to/with	741
G4632	σκεῦος	skeuos	vessel	23
G5092	τιμή	time	honor	44

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern across law, wisdom, gospel, and epistle condemns the constituent acts of the practice: the deliberate look aimed at sexual desire, sexual immorality (porneia), the controlling passion of lust, and the dishonoring use of the body. Matt 5.28 reads *pas ho blepon gynaika pros to epithymesai auten ede emoiceusen auten en te kardia autou*, where the present active participle *blepon* plus the articular infinitive of purpose *pros to epithymesai* names a look whose aim is lust, and the aorist *emoicheusen* with adverbial *ede* and locative *en te kardia* fixes the guilt as already complete before any external act. 1 Thess 4.3-5 makes *hagiasmos* the *thelema* of God, defined as *apechesthai apo tes porneias* and refusing *pathos epithymias kathaper ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon*, with the body kept *en hagiasmo kai time*. 1 Cor 6.18 commands *pheugete ten porneian*. Job 31.1 records *berith karatti le einay* (a covenant I cut with my eyes) so as not to gaze *al bethulah*. Ps 101.3 vows *lo ashit le neged einay devar beliyaal*. The convergence of Decalogue internalization, wisdom discipline of the eye, and Pauline

sanctification ethic, on the same juncture (the desiring look that engages illicit sexual interest), is what makes the verdict decisive rather than disputed.

Scripture

Matt.5.27 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3431 μοιχεύω

Force. Ekousate hoti errethe, ou moicheuseis (you heard that it was said, you shall not commit adultery). The future indicative moicheuseis recites the seventh commandment of Exod 20.14 and Deut 5.18 as the inherited prohibition. Jesus cites the external statute as the foil against which he will extend the prohibition inward in v.28. The verse establishes that the baseline standard under discussion is adultery itself, not a lesser matter.

Matt.5.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0991 βλέπω, G4314 πρόσ, G1937 ἐπιθυμέω, G3431 μοιχεύω, G2588 καρδιά, G2235 ἤδη

Force. Ego de lego hymin hoti pas ho blepon gynaika pros to epithymesai auten ede emoicheusen auten en te kardia autou. The present active participle blepon (the one looking) is qualified by the articular infinitive of purpose pros to epithymesai (in order to desire her), naming not an accidental glance but a look whose aim is lust. The aorist indicative emoicheusen (committed adultery) with the adverb ede (already) and the locative phrase en te kardia (in the heart) declares the guilt complete before any external act. The construction places the moral violation precisely at the point of intentional, desiring looking, which is the defining act of the practice under examination.

1Thess.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2307 θέλημα, G2316 θεός, G0038 ἁγιασμός, G0568 ἀπέχω, G4202 πορνεία

Force. Touto gar estin thelema tou theou, ho hagasmos hymon, apechesthai hymas apo tes porneias. The predicate nominative chain identifies the thelema (will) of God with hagasmos (sanctification), then explicates it with the present middle infinitive apechesthai (to keep abstaining) governed by apo tes porneias (from sexual immorality). Porneia is the broad noun covering the whole field of illicit sexual activity, and the durative infinitive makes abstention an ongoing state, not a single decision. Sanctification is defined negatively as continuous distance from porneia.

1Thess.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1538 ἕκαστος, G4632 σκεῦος, G2932 κτάομαι, G5092 τιμή, G0038 ἁγιασμός

Force. Eidenai hekaston hymon to heautou skeuos ktasthai en hagasmo kai time. The distributive hekaston (each one) makes the command individual. The present infinitive ktasthai (to gain control of, to possess) takes to heautou skeuos (his own vessel, the body or the marital relation) as object, governed by the dual prepositional phrase en hagasmo kai time (in sanctification and honor). Time (honor) is the antonym of degrading treatment of the body or of another person. The positive command frames the body and the sexual capacity as something to be held in honor, which the degrading consumption of illicit sexual imagery directly violates.

1Thess.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3361 μή, G3806 πάθος, G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G2509 καθάπερ, G1484 ἔθνος

Force. Me en pathei epithymias kathaper kai ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon. The prohibition me en pathei epithymias (not in the passion of lust) names the inner disposition forbidden, with pathos (a rare term, three canonical occurrences only, at Rom 1.26, Col 3.5, 1 Thess 4.5) denoting a controlling passion and epithymias as its content. The comparison kathaper kai ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon (just as the nations that do not know God) marks lust driven sexual conduct as the mark of those outside the knowledge of God, the inverse of hagasmos. The verse couples illicit sexual desire with ignorance of God, placing it categorically outside sanctified conduct.

1Cor.6.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία

Force. Pheugete ten porneian. The present active imperative pheugete (keep fleeing) with the definite article ten porneian governs the whole category of illicit sexual activity, with the article generalizing porneia as a whole rather than naming a single act. The continuous-aspect imperative makes flight the standing posture toward porneia, not a one-time decision. The verse stands as the most concise positive Pauline command on the category and corroborates 1 Thess 4.3.

Job.31.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H1285 ברית, H3772 כרת, H5869 עין, H0995 בין, H1330 בתולה.

Force. Berith karatti le einay umah etbonen al bethulah (a covenant I cut with my eyes, so how could I gaze upon a virgin). The idiom karath berith (to cut a covenant) is the standard Hebrew formula for binding oneself by oath (over 80 collocations in the canon), here applied to einayim (the eyes) as the organ of desiring sight. The hithpolel etbonen (from bin) means to gaze attentively or consider closely, and the rhetorical umah (so how) treats such a gaze as a covenant breach. ETCBC marks the clause as a question (Ques) functioning to deny. Job locates moral self governance precisely at the controlled use of the eyes toward the female object of potential lust, the same act Matt 5.28 condemns.

Ps.101.3 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H7896 שית, H5869 עין, H1697 דבר, H1100 בליעל.

Force. Lo ashit le neged einay devar beliyaal (I will not set before my eyes a worthless or wicked thing). The imperfect ashit (I will set) negated by lo expresses settled resolve, and le neged einay (before my eyes) makes the visual field the object of moral guarding. Devar beliyaal (a thing of beliyaal, worthlessness or wickedness) names whatever is morally corrupting placed before the sight. The verse establishes a positive discipline of refusing corrupting things before the eyes, the direct counterpart to deliberately viewing illicit sexual material.

Exod.20.14 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H5003 נאך.

Force. Lo tinaph (you shall not commit adultery). The seventh word of the Decalogue using the qal imperfect of naaph (the Hebrew verb of adultery), negated by lo. The Septuagint renders this as ou moicheuseis with moicheuo, which is the exact verb Jesus cites in Matt 5.27 and the same verb he applies to the heart act in 5.28, demonstrating continuity between the external statute and the interior extension.

Prov.6.25 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H2530A תמד, H5869 עין, H6079 עפעץ.

Force. Al tahmod yafyah bilvavekha ve al tiqqahaka be afappeyha (do not desire her beauty in your heart, nor let her capture you with her eyelids). The jussive al tahmod (do not covet, from hamad, the verb of the tenth commandment) takes yafyah (her beauty) as object and bilvavekha (in your heart) as the locus, exactly paralleling Matt 5.28 en te kardia. The second clause warns against capture be afappeyha (by her eyelids, the visual lure). Wisdom literature already locates the sin in the heart level desire provoked through the eyes, confirming the Matthean reading is a development of an existing canonical pattern.

Col.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4202 πορνεία, G3806 πάθος, G1939 ἐπιθυμία

Force. Nekrosate oun ta mele ta epi tes ges, porneian, akatharsian, pathos, epithymian kaken, kai ten pleonexian. The aorist active imperative nekrosate (put to death) governs an asyndetic list whose first four items overlap exactly with the 1 Thess 4.3-5 vocabulary, porneia plus pathos plus epithymia. The same Pauline triad applied to a different audience confirms that the lexical complex is not Thessalonian local, it is the standing Pauline category.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.5.27	Exod.20.14	tsk	1
Matt.5.28	Gen.34.2	tsk	1
Matt.5.28	Ps.119.96	tsk	1
Job.31.1	Gen.6.2	tsk	1
Job.31.1	Prov.6.25	tsk	1
Ps.101.3	1Kgs.21.13	tsk	1
Ps.101.3	Deut.13.17	tsk	1
Ps.101.3	Ps.97.10	tsk	1
1Thess.4.3	1Thess.5.18	tsk	1
1Thess.4.4	1Sam.21.5	tsk	1
1Thess.4.3	1Cor.6.18	openbible	1
1Thess.4.5	Col.3.5	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Matt.5.28 · addressed

The stem says pornography use is sin, but the word pornography names a modern technology and does not occur in the canon. One could object that the lexical anchors address adultery, fornication, and gazing at actual persons, not viewing images. Resolution, Matt 5.28 fixes guilt at the point of *blepon pros to epithymesai* (looking in order to lust), and the object of the look (*gynaika*, a woman) is the same morally whether the woman is physically present or depicted. The morally relevant act named by the verb plus the purpose infinitive is the intentional engagement of sexual desire through sight, which is identically present when the object is a depicted person. The lexical pattern condemns the constituent act regardless of medium.

1Thess.4.4 · addressed

Skeuos (vessel) is lexically ambiguous between the man's own body (the dominant Greek metaphor, cf. 2 Cor 4.7) and his wife (a possible Hebraic idiom). If *skeuos* means wife, one might restrict v.4 to acquiring a spouse honorably and read it as silent on solitary viewing. Resolution, either reading supports the verdict. If *skeuos* is the body, the command to possess it *en hagio* *smo kai time* forbids degrading sexual use. If it is the wife, the command to hold the marital relation in honor is corroded by *porneia* and *pathos epithymias*, which v.3 and v.5 forbid in any case. The surrounding *apechesthai apo tes porneias* and *me en pathei epithymias* carry the verdict independent of the *skeuos* decision.

Job.31.1 · addressed

Job 31.1 is a personal vow within a self-imprecation oath, and one might say it expresses one righteous man's private scruple rather than a universal norm. Resolution, the clause uses the formal covenant idiom *karath berith*, the strongest available binding language in biblical Hebrew, and the rhetorical question *umah etbonen* treats the desiring gaze as self-evidently a covenant breach for the upright. The wisdom genre presents Job as standard as exemplary, and Prov 6.25 generalizes the same heart and eye dynamic into instruction. The vow form does not weaken the lexical witness that the desiring look is morally culpable.

Matt.5.28 · addressed

A second possible reading of *pas ho blepon gynaika pros to epithymesai auten* (everyone looking at a woman in order to lust for her) takes *pros plus articular infinitive* as result rather than purpose, yielding (so as to lust for her). The result reading would broaden the rule to include the involuntary involvement of desire as well as deliberate desiring. Resolution, the purpose sense is the strongly attested default for *pros plus articular infinitive* in Koine, and either reading supports the verdict in the case of pornography. Deliberate viewing of sexual imagery satisfies the purpose reading directly, and a fortiori satisfies the broader result reading. The verdict is robust across both lexically defensible glosses of the construction.

Concordance traversed

G3431, G0991, G1937, G1939, G2588, G4314, G4202, G0038, G0568, G4632, G2932, G5092, G3806, G1484, G2307, G2509, G1538, G2235, H1285, H3772, H5869, H0995, H1330, H1100, H1697, H7896, H5003, H2530A, H6079, H5048

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

auto-matt5-28-auten at Matt.5.28: impact none. Some witnesses omit or relocate *auten* (her) after *epithymesai*, and a few read *pros to epithymesai autes*. The verb *moicheuo* plus the locative *en te kardia* and the participle *blepon* are uniformly attested across the manuscript tradition, so the verdict that the desiring look is heart adultery is unaffected.

auto-1thess4-4-skeuos at 1Thess.4.4: impact none. The lexical referent of *skeuos* (body versus wife) is debated as a matter of glossing, but the manuscript text is stable. The surrounding *apechesthai apo tes porneias* and *me en pathai epithymias* secure the verdict regardless of how *skeuos* is glossed.

No ECM apparatus was examined for these verses, and no load bearing textual decision rests on a contested variant. The Greek anchors lie outside the 3 John CBGM sample, so the status is shadow.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. *decatalogue_internalization*, *wisdom_ethics*, *pauline_sanctification*

analogia scripturae invoked · *progressive revelation* factor

Decalogue internalization (Matt 5.27-28 extending Exod 20.14): affirms · Jesus takes *ou moicheuseis* and relocates the violation to *blepon pros to epithymesai*, the intentional desiring look, with *ede emoicheusen* marking completed guilt in the heart. The defining act of the practice is precisely this look.

Wisdom ethics of the guarded eye (Job 31.1, Ps 101.3, Prov 6.25): affirms · Job cuts a berith with his eyes against gazing, the psalmist refuses *devar beliyaal* before his eyes, and Proverbs forbids desiring beauty in the heart and capture by the eyelids. The wisdom corpus already disciplines the eye as the gateway to illicit desire.

Pauline sanctification ethic (1 Thess 4.3-5, 1 Cor 6.18, Col 3.5): affirms · *Hagiasmos* is the thelema of God, defined as *apechesthai apo tes porneias* and refusing *pathos epithymias*, with the body held *en time*. Lust driven sexual conduct is marked as the way of *ta ethne ta me eidota ton theon*, the opposite of sanctification. 1 Cor 6.18 commands *pheugete ten porneian*, and Col 3.5 lists the same *porneia*, *pathos*, *epithymia* triad.

Narrow medium objection (the object of view is a depicted person, not the looker is neighbor): partially complicates but does not overturn · A reader could press that Matt 5.28 names *gynaika* as the object of the look, suggesting a known person, and that Job 31.1 names *bethulah* as a real young woman in proximity. The strongest form of this lens reads the prohibition as restricted to looking at one is potential neighbor with intent to act, not to interaction with images. The lexical answer is that the participial construction *blepon plus purpose infinitive epithymesai* locates the guilt in the looker is internal aim, not in the relational status of the object, and Paul forbids the inner state *pathos epithymias* itself in 1 Thess 4.5, independent of who provoked it. The lens does not survive the

grammar.

The verdict turns on the convergence of Decalogue internalization, wisdom discipline of the eye, and Pauline sanctification ethics. The term pornography is post canonical, so the lexical case proceeds by identifying the practice is constituent acts (the desiring look, porneia, the passion of lust, the dishonoring of the body) and showing each is condemned across the canon. Progressive revelation is in play in that Matt 5.28 makes explicit and interior what the seventh and tenth commandments and the wisdom literature already pointed toward.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the lexical pattern of the canon treat deliberate looking aimed at sexual desire, sexual immorality (porneia), the passion of lust, and the dishonoring of the body and marriage as sin.

The stem asserts the verdict (pornography use is sin) and supplies three rationales (heart adultery, exploitation, corrosion of the marriage bed). The word pornography itself is a modern term absent from the canon (descended morphologically from porneia plus grapho, the writing or depicting of porneia), so the stem is verdict loaded relative to the lexical store and must be neutralized to its constituent acts. The lexical anchors directly address the desiring look (Matt 5.28), porneia and the passion of lust (1 Thess 4.3-5, 1 Cor 6.18, Col 3.5), and the guarding of the eyes (Job 31.1, Ps 101.3, Prov 6.25). The exploitation of persons in the industry and the corrosion of the marriage bed are downstream moral and sociological claims that the lexical store does not directly measure, so the verdict rests on the heart adultery and porneia strands, which are unambiguous, rather than on the exploitation or marriage corrosion clauses. The verdict is derived on the original stem but anchored only where the lexical evidence speaks.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.5.28
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.3
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.5
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.18
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morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.101.3
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.20.14
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.6.25
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G3431
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G4202
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G3806
lexicon	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	H1285
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Job.31.1
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.101.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.5.28
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Job.31.1
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